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PSYC100

The bystander effect

Today
Welcome to your next lesson: The bystander effect.

I'm preparing your personalized lesson based on what you've learned, what's coming next, and how you learn best.

Step by step, you’re moving forward.

Imagine you’re walking through a busy parking lot. Someone trips, falls hard, and just lies there. There are 15 other people around.

A minute passes. No one helps.

Not because they’re evil — but because everyone is kind of waiting for someone else to do something.

That pattern has a name: the bystander effect — when people are less likely to help in an emergency if other people are present.

Quick check, just your instinct ⚡

Does that parking-lot scene feel more like:

A) “People don’t want to help”
B) “People do want to help, but the situation makes them freeze or wait”?

You can just answer A or B.

b

Yes, I agree with you — B is the idea behind the bystander effect 👍

People often do want to help, but certain forces in the situation make them hesitate, freeze, or assume “someone else will step in.”

Let’s zoom in on one of those forces: diffusion of responsibility.

Diffusion of responsibility = when there are many people around, each person feels less personally responsible to act.

Simple picture:

You’re the only one who sees a car crash → “I have to call 911.”
You’re 1 of 20 people who see it → “Someone must have called already.”

Same person, different situation → different behavior.

Does this basic idea of responsibility spreading out and getting weaker when more people are around make sense so far?

Yes, that makes sense

Nice 👍

I've just pulled up a short video called "The bystander effect | the science of empathy."

It shows real-life situations where people do or don't step in to help.

Go ahead and watch it 👀

While you watch, notice in each scene:

Are people looking around at what others are doing?
Does it seem like they're waiting for someone else to act?
When you're done, tell me:

Did any one scene in the video stand out to you the most? What happened in it?

the one guy that stared talking to someone behind him to tease the instructyor hhaving issues stood out, hard to tell from the video if they were looking for someone else to help they really werent looking a others

Yeah, that moment was rough to watch 😬

He wasn't even confused — he saw the instructor struggling and turned it into a joke.

That's a great example for us, because:

He did notice the problem
He did interpret it as something real (not a prank)
But he chose to mock instead of help

So here, the issue isn't "waiting for others" — it's more like dehumanizing the person or trying to look cool.

Now I want to connect this to a simple 5-step "helping" path psychologists use:

Notice something is happening
Interpret it as an emergency
Decide "it's my responsibility to help"
Know how to help
Actually take action

In strong bystander effect, we usually get stuck at step 3:

"It's not really my job… someone else will do it."

I'll pause here.

Does this 5-step path to helping make sense so far, or should I rewrite it in a quick table/diagram style for you?

It makes sense

What do you think? Pick the option that best matches how we described diffusion of

responsibility 👇

Which option BEST describes diffusion of responsibility in the bystander effect?

A.

When people copy others to fit in with a group, even if they think it’s wrong.

B.

When people feel less personally responsible to help because many others are present.

C.

When people obey direct orders from an authority figure, even if they disagree.

D.

When people don’t notice an emergency because they are distracted by their phones.

b

Nice, thanks for answering 👍

You picked an option, so now let’s practice the idea in a concrete scenario to be sure it’s solid.

Imagine this:

You’re in a crowded office. A coworker in another cubicle suddenly sounds panicked and says they feel dizzy and might pass out.

You hear it. You also hear other coworkers go a bit quiet, but nobody moves yet.

In a strong diffusion of responsibility situation, what’s most likely going through people’s minds?

A) “No one else is here, I have to do something.”

B) “There are plenty of people around; someone will handle it.”

C) “This is definitely not real, it’s just a prank.”

Just type A, B, or C.

b

Exactly — B is the heart of diffusion of responsibility 🎯

“Lots of people are around… someone will take care of it.”

That’s the quiet thought that makes everyone less likely to act.

Now I want to bring in one more piece that often works together with diffusion: pluralistic ignorance (we’ll keep it simple).

Picture this like a little chain:

You look around: no one is moving, everyone looks calm
You think: “Maybe it’s not that serious… if it were, people would be reacting.”
So you stay calm too

Everyone else looks at you staying calm and thinks the same thing

So:

Pluralistic ignorance = “Everyone else looks calm, so it must not be an emergency.”

It feeds the bystander effect because if you think it’s not really an emergency, you never reach the step where you feel responsible.

Quick gut check:

If you were in a store and smelled smoke, but everyone else kept shopping calmly… would you feel at least a little pull to “wait and see” instead of acting right away?

a little yeah total opposite of not thinking thres a fire, no smoke yet ppnick peopel yell fire and run id run too

That reaction makes a lot of sense 💯

In the smoke but everyone calm case → you feel that “wait and see” pull (that’s where pluralistic ignorance kicks in).
In the no smoke but people screaming “FIRE!” case → you’d likely join the running (that’s social influence in a more panic direction).

Both times, what other people do strongly shapes what you do.

To beat the bystander effect, a powerful trick is to flip the script in your own head:

Instead of: “Someone will handle it.”

Say: “If I don’t act, maybe no one will.”

Let’s turn this into something practical for your life 🔧

Give me 2 concrete things you could do next time you see someone who might need help (could be at work, in a store, on the street, etc.).

Short phrases are fine, like “ask directly if they’re okay” or “call 911 instead of assuming someone else did.”

well hate to say it but you answerd for me, go ask them if they need help or if they are pased out or obvous need call 911

And that exactly is how you beat the bystander effect in real life 💪

Your two moves are solid:

Go ask directly: “Hey, are you okay? Do you need help?”
Call 911 if they’re passed out / clearly in trouble, instead of assuming someone else already did.

Those both cut through diffusion of responsibility — you treat it as your job, not “someone’s” job.

Before we wrap this lesson, I want to make sure the key idea is clear in your own words:

How would you explain diffusion of responsibility to a friend who’s never taken psychology?

One simple sentence is enough.

diffusion of respnsibility is the effect of being in a group of people who dont respond to an apparaant emrgency , you noticce the others and also dont act depite your normal values and empathy

That’s a strong explanation, Ron 🔥
You captured both the group part and the “despite your values and empathy” part — that’s exactly the point.

Quick recap in clean form:

Bystander effect: you’re less likely to help when more people are around.
Diffusion of responsibility: in a group, each person feels less personally responsible → “someone else will do it.”
Pluralistic ignorance: you see others staying calm and think, “Guess it’s not serious,” so you also do nothing.
Your counter-strategy:
Go directly to the person: “Are you okay?”
Call 911 if it’s clearly serious, instead of assuming others did.
You’ve nailed the core idea for this lesson 🎯

From here, your next lessons will keep building on how situations quietly shape behavior, just like we saw with obedience, conformity, and now the bystander effect.

If you want, we can:

Connect this to a real event you remember from your life, or
Move on and let the platform take you to the next lesson
What feels right for you right now?